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Multi-Step Processes

Some word problems require only one operation or step. But other problems may require you to use multiple operations and steps to get the answer. Be sure to read the problem carefully so you know you are answering the right question. Take a look at this multi-step word problem.

EXAMPLE

On Monday, Fast Copy had 325 cases of copy paper in stock. By the end of the week, it had only 210 cases in stock. The company orders 300 cases every Monday morning. If Fast Copy uses twice as much paper next week, will it have enough? → How much paper will be used?

Step 1 Understand the question.

Put the question in your own words. What do you need to find out?

I need to know how many cases of copy paper would be used if Fast Copy used twice as much as last week.

Step 2 Find the facts you need.

What numbers will help you answer the question?

The company started with 325 cases. It ended the week with 210 cases.

The company orders 300 cases every Monday.

Step 3 Choose operations.

Operations

- Add to combine numbers.
- Subtract to find a difference.
- Multiply to add a number many times.
- Divide to cut a larger number into equal parts.

To find the difference between the starting and ending number of cases, subtract.

Step 4 Do the work.

$$\begin{array}{r} 325 \\ -\ 210 \\ \hline 115 \end{array}$$

Fast Copy used **115 cases** of copy paper.

If they use twice as much next week, figure out how much that is:

$115 \times 2 = 230$

Step 5 Look back.

Think: Does your answer make sense? Does it answer the question?

If they use twice as much paper, they will use 230 cases. They will order 300 cases on Monday.

Use estimation: $300 - 230 = 70$.

If they order 300 cases, they will still have enough paper.

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Lesson 3: Solving Problems

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